

LIBERTY CYBER THREAT INTELLIGENCE

THE ALAMO THREAT BRIEF™

OPEN SOURCE INTELLIGENCE

ISSUE	ATB-2026-10
COVERAGE PERIOD	10–16 MAY 2026
PUBLICATION DATE	2026-05-17
DOMINANT JUDGMENT	TEXAS IS THE TARGET SYSTEM

Executive decision intelligence for Texas critical infrastructure.

Executive Warning: Texas infrastructure concentration is now the risk, not the backdrop. This week’s reporting shows three pressure points converging: grid-demand growth, critical OT vulnerability exposure, and federal planning assumptions that adversaries may already hold access inside U.S. critical infrastructure. For Texas executives, the decision is no longer whether cyber risk belongs in the boardroom. The decision is whether continuity plans still work when power, telecom, cloud, vendors, and financial recovery functions degrade together. Leadership should use this week to validate external dependencies, assign reporting ownership, and document what risk it is accepting before summer demand pressure rises.

Board Implications This Week — Ask

Which external dependency fails first if power, telecom, cloud, MSP, identity access, or vendor support is degraded? Do not let the answer stay inside IT. This is a leadership continuity question.

Board Implications This Week — Direct

Require a 90-minute executive dependency mapping session before the next board or risk committee meeting. The session should cover power, telecom, cloud, MSP, identity, finance, suppliers, and manual workarounds.

Board Implications This Week — Document

Record the assumptions leadership is accepting on backup power, vendor availability, CIRCIA ownership, ransomware payment authority, and manual continuity. If those assumptions are wrong, the record will matter.

Board Implications This Week — Rehearse

Run one combined cyber/physical continuity scenario before peak summer grid demand. Do not test a cyber incident in one room and a power-continuity problem in another. That is not how the failure will arrive.

CENTERPIECE ANALYSIS

The dominant analytic call this week is not about one intrusion. It is about what the threat environment looks like when Texas is viewed as a coupled operating system. Current-week reporting on ERCOT demand pressure, ICS exposure, healthcare ransomware, and CI Fortify governance expectations points to the same problem: adversaries do not need to defeat every sector. They only need to disrupt the node that creates the most pressure across the system.

Texas energy, healthcare, financial services, defense, telecom, and AI infrastructure are not individually targeted at random. They are connected nodes in a high-value disruption system. Grid stress affects hospitals. Telecom disruption affects payment recovery. Cloud and MSP disruption affect identity, dispatch, claims, billing, and logistics. Data-center growth increases the power dependency at the same time federal guidance is telling operators to prepare for degraded vendor and network support.

Bottom line: CI Fortify aligns with two years of open-source federal warning about nation-state pre-positioning against U.S. critical infrastructure. It is not current-week reporting, but it is now the baseline against which this week's grid, ICS, healthcare, and governance reporting must be judged. Act on it now, on your own timeline.

Section I

What Changed This Week

CISA 16-Advisory ICS Release — Energy and Healthcare Attack Surface Confirmed

On **14 May 2026**, CISA published sixteen ICS advisories covering Siemens, ABB, Hitachi Energy, Johnson Controls, and Schneider Electric — vendors embedded across energy, manufacturing, healthcare, and industrial environments. Several advisories carried critical severity. The decision problem is not whether every affected device exists inside a given enterprise. The decision problem is whether leadership knows which third parties, facilities, or suppliers depend on exposed OT and industrial systems.

ERCOT Demand Forecast vs. Grid Reality

ERCOT's April 2026 long-term load forecast projected statewide demand reaching nearly 368 GW by 2032, driven heavily by AI data centers. The Public Utility Commission rejected the preliminary 112 GW summer 2026 figure as inflated, but even revised conservative projections of 90.5–98 GW this summer would exceed the all-time peak demand record of 85.5 GW set in 2023. Texas leaders should treat this as a continuity planning issue, not only a grid planning issue.

Healthcare Ransomware Reporting — Patient Safety, Not Just Data Protection

On **15 May 2026**, healthcare ransomware reporting reinforced that health systems remain inside an elevated extortion environment. For Texas hospitals and regional providers, the operational question is whether patient movement, EHR access, imaging, pharmacy, revenue cycle, and third-party care coordination can continue when cloud, telecom, or vendor support is degraded.

CI Fortify Governance Interpretation — Continuing Baseline, Current-Week Legal Relevance

CI Fortify launched on **5 May 2026**, outside this ATB's collection window. It is therefore carried forward as a continuing baseline, not counted as a current-week event. The current-week development is the legal and governance interpretation published on 14 May: boards and executives should expect CI Fortify to shape what reasonable preparation looks like after a critical infrastructure incident.

Section II

Key Judgments

KJ-1

Liberty CTI assesses it is **likely** (55–80%) that Texas infrastructure concentration itself — AI compute load, ERCOT grid dependency, telecom corridor concentration, and MSP/cloud access consolidation — has become a strategic objective for nation-state adversary pre-positioning. **MODERATE CONFIDENCE**

Source basis / uncertainty: Source basis: CISA CI Fortify planning assumptions carried forward from 5 May 2026; CISA/NSA/FBI Volt Typhoon Advisory AA24-038A; ERCOT April 2026 Long-Term Load Forecast and 14 May reporting; CISA ICS advisories published 14 May 2026. Primary uncertainty: no confirmed active Texas intrusion was identified in open reporting this week; this is an analytic inference from adversary intent, target value, and dependency concentration.

Decision implication: Decision Implication: Risk officers should reframe their threat model from sector-specific cyber incidents to coupled-system degradation scenarios. The attack surface is the dependency map, not only the perimeter.

KJ-2

Liberty CTI assesses it is **likely** (55–80%) that Texas healthcare cyber risk will increasingly manifest as operational continuity and patient-safety risk, not only data-protection risk. **HIGH CONFIDENCE**

Source basis / uncertainty: Source basis: Healthcare IT Today reporting on 15 May 2026; CISA ICS advisories including medical-device and industrial-system exposure on 14 May 2026; sustained ransomware activity against health systems. Primary uncertainty: the open-source record does not identify a new major Texas health-system disruption during this collection window.

Decision implication: Decision Implication: Hospital boards and health system CEOs should add telecom, cloud, EHR, backup power, and patient-transfer dependencies to patient-safety risk registers this quarter.

KJ-3

Liberty CTI assesses it is **likely** (55–80%) that ERCOT grid stress during summer 2026 will create exploitable operational vulnerability windows if cyber, physical, and vendor-continuity plans remain separated. **MODERATE CONFIDENCE**

Source basis / uncertainty: Source basis: ERCOT April 2026 Long-Term Load Forecast and 14 May 2026 reporting showing conservative summer-demand estimates above the historical peak; CISA CI Fortify assumptions on degraded vendor and network support; current-week CISA ICS advisories. Primary uncertainty: actual summer peak demand, weather-driven load, and realized data-center consumption remain uncertain.

Decision implication: Decision Implication: Large grid consumers and ERCOT-connected critical infrastructure operators should confirm that cyber incident response plans and physical continuity plans are integrated, not separate documents.

Section III

Geopolitical Driver

The strategic driver is adversary preparation for crisis leverage against U.S. critical infrastructure. PRC pre-positioning remains tied to contingency planning around Taiwan and regional military pressure. Iranian OT targeting remains tied to retaliation capacity during Middle East escalation. DPRK IT-worker activity remains tied to sanctions evasion and weapons-program revenue. Texas matters because its grid, defense, healthcare, finance, telecom, and AI/data-center growth give adversaries multiple ways to create pressure beyond the initial victim.

CRITICAL INTELLIGENCE WARNING

Continuum assessment: Texas remains in **competition**, but the warning indicators that matter are crisis enablers: access development, dependency mapping, OT exposure, telecom concentration, cloud and MSP reliance, and leadership assumptions that have not been tested under degraded conditions.

Section IV

Why This Matters to Texas

Texas is not simply a collection of targeted sectors. It is a coupled operating system. Energy enables the rest of the economy. Finance enables recovery. Healthcare carries immediate human consequence. The defense industrial base carries national security consequence. AI and data centers increase power demand and concentrate cloud dependency. The board-level risk is not a single cyber event. It is the cascade that follows when one dependency fails and leadership discovers the continuity plan assumed the rest of the system would still be available.

Cross-Sector Cascade Assessment

Energy ERCOT / OT / Grid	What changed: ERCOT's revised summer 2026 peak demand estimate of 90.5–98 GW already exceeds the all-time record. CISA's 14 May ICS advisories flagged critical vulnerabilities in industrial vendors deployed across energy environments. Why it matters locally: Texas grid operators face concurrent pressure: data-center growth assumes continuous, high-bandwidth, vendor-rich operations; federal resilience guidance assumes the opposite must be survivable. Cascade risk: Energy disruption cascades to healthcare, water, finance, telecom, and fuel logistics within hours.
Financial Payments / Recovery / Compliance	What changed: CIRCIA readiness, ransomware payment authority, insurance claim handling, and vendor payment recovery are now leadership dependencies. Why it matters locally: Texas CFOs and risk officers who treat financial disruption as a banking problem are misframing the exposure. Financial recovery capacity is operational continuity. Cascade risk: Finance-sector degradation during an energy, cloud, or telecom disruption extends restoration timelines by days, not hours.

Healthcare / DIB
Patient Safety /
Supply Chain

Healthcare: Ransomware pressure and current-week reporting reinforce that health systems face continuity risk, not only privacy risk. Texas providers dependent on cloud-hosted EHR platforms or telecom-dependent care coordination carry compounding exposure when grid and telecom degrade together. **DIB:** DPRK IT-worker activity remains a carried-forward supply-chain warning from ATB-2026-9. The route into sensitive environments may be a supplier, MSP, staffing process, or remote-hire pipeline. **Cascade risk:** Healthcare degradation creates immediate safety pressure; DIB degradation creates national security and contract-performance pressure.

Section V

Indicators & Warnings — PIR Watch, 1 to 4 Weeks

PIR 2 / I&W 1 ERCOT grid-load stress events near AI compute corridors [Rising]

- Watch for unplanned load-shedding, transmission anomalies, curtailment events, or emergency reliability messaging in data-center-concentrated corridors as summer demand ramps.
- Would confirm dependency compression is translating into operational vulnerability windows that adversaries can time and exploit.
- Tied to: PIR 2, cross-sector cascading cyber and operational risk.

PIR 6 / I&W 2 CI Fortify resilience assessment requests reaching Texas operators [Rising]

- Watch for CISA regional advisors initiating targeted assessments with Texas energy, healthcare, water, telecom, or defense-critical operators.
- Would confirm federal situational awareness is tracking specific Texas resilience gaps and that the voluntary preparation window is narrowing.
- Tied to: PIR 6, executive decision-relevant warning.

PIR 1 / I&W 3 DPRK RevGen indictment naming a Texas-connected firm [Rising]

- Watch for DOJ indictments or disclosures under DPRK RevGen naming Texas-headquartered or Texas-operating companies as victim organizations.
- Would confirm that supply-chain hiring and remote-work controls are not abstract national risks; they are local Texas exposure.
- Tied to: PIR 1, nation-state targeting of Texas critical infrastructure.

PIR 5 / I&W 4 Texas health system or DIB supplier ransomware disclosure [Sustained]

- Watch for HHS OCR breach notifications, SEC 8-K filings, or local operational disruption reporting naming Texas-region health systems or defense subcontractors.
- Would confirm threat actors are monetizing access locally rather than only holding access for future leverage.
- Tied to: PIR 5, strategic vulnerability exposure across critical infrastructure.

PIR 3 / I&W 5 PRC or Iran geopolitical escalation signals [Sustained]

- Watch for material escalation in Taiwan Strait military posturing, expanded Iranian OT targeting disclosures, or federal advisories expanding CI Fortify framing to name Texas sectors.
- Would shift Liberty CTI's posture from competition monitoring toward crisis preparation for affected sectors.
- Tied to: PIR 3 and PIR 7, escalation indicators and geopolitical-cyber acceleration.

Section VI

Governance Implication Block

Decision at risk	Whether your organization's continuity and recovery assumptions remain valid under simultaneous infrastructure degradation — power, telecom, cloud, identity, finance, and vendor dependencies failing in combination rather than in isolation.
Owner	Board risk committee / CEO / COO / CISO / General Counsel. CFO ownership is required where payment recovery, insurance, liquidity, or vendor payment timing affects restoration.
Consequence of delay	Extended downtime, patient or operational safety consequences, CIRCIA regulatory exposure, insurance disputes, litigation posture weakness, contract-performance risk, public scrutiny, and loss of executive credibility if leadership cannot show it considered the dependency risk before the event.
Action this week	Ask which external dependency fails first. Approve a 90-minute dependency mapping session. Assign CIRCIA ownership. Rehearse one combined cyber/physical continuity scenario before peak summer demand.
Record to preserve	Board minutes, risk committee notes, counsel-led documentation, dependency maps, accepted-risk decisions, continuity planning assumptions, CIRCIA ownership assignment, and tabletop findings. If regulatory inquiry, insurance claim, or litigation follows an incident, the absence of this record is itself a governance finding.

From Warning to Decision

Test what this means for your organization.

Reading the warning is one thing. Knowing whether your leadership would recognize it, decide in time, and document the call is another. Liberty CTI starts by establishing your decision environment, then tests it under pressure.

EXECUTIVE INTELLIGENCE BASELINE + EXECUTIVE DECISION EXERCISE →

Section VII

Actions This Week

CRITICAL INTELLIGENCE WARNING

Ask: Which critical business function fails first if power, telecom, cloud, MSP, identity, or a key supplier is unavailable?

Approve: A 90-minute executive dependency mapping session with CEO, COO, CISO/CIO, GC, CFO, and business continuity ownership in the room.

Document: CIRCIA reporting owner, ransomware payment authority, backup power assumptions, manual operating procedures, and risk accepted by leadership.

Rehearse: One integrated scenario: cyber intrusion plus grid stress plus degraded telecom plus unavailable vendor support.

Section VIII

Prior Judgment Tracker

Prior judgment	ATB-2026-9 assessed that DPRK IT-worker activity was shifting from isolated fraud toward a recurring supply-chain governance risk.
Current status	Unchanged. No new current-week Texas-named case was identified, but enforcement cadence remains elevated and the supply-chain governance issue remains active.
What changed	This week's dominant movement was not DPRK. It was the convergence of ERCOT demand pressure, CISA ICS exposure, healthcare ransomware reporting, and CI Fortify governance interpretation.
Confidence movement	Confidence in Texas cross-sector cascade exposure increased from Moderate to High because multiple independent reporting streams now point to the same dependency problem.
Next indicator	A Texas-named victim, sector-specific CI Fortify follow-on guidance, major ERCOT summer reliability warning, confirmed exploitation of one of the 14 May ICS vulnerabilities, or geopolitical escalation involving PRC or Iran would raise escalation posture.

Section IX — Sourcing

Open Source Basis

PRIMARY SOURCES — ATB-2026-10 — COVERAGE WEEK 10–16 MAY 2026 AND CONTINUING BASELINE

GOVERNMENT / REGULATORY

CISA — CI Fortify Initiative

[cisa.gov/news-events/news/cisa-unveils-new-initiative-fortify-americas-critical-infrastructure](https://www.cisa.gov/news-events/news/cisa-unveils-new-initiative-fortify-americas-critical-infrastructure)

Published 5 May 2026. Carried forward as continuing baseline, not counted as current-week reporting. Used for Executive Warning, Dominant Judgment, and Governance Implication Block.

GOVERNMENT / REGULATORY

CISA/NSA/FBI — Advisory AA24-038A: PRC State-Sponsored Actors & U.S. Critical Infrastructure

cisa.gov/news-events/cybersecurity-advisories/aa24-038a

Basis for Volt Typhoon pre-positioning assessment. Reaffirmed in ODNI 2026 Annual Threat Assessment.

GOVERNMENT / REGULATORY

EPA/FBI/CISA/NSA — Joint Advisory: Iranian-Affiliated Cyber Attacks on U.S. Critical Infrastructure

epa.gov/newsreleases/epa-fbi-cisa-nsa-issue-joint-cybersecurity-advisory-water-system-regarding-iranian

Published 7 April 2026. Basis for Iranian OT targeting assessment.

GOVERNMENT / REGULATORY

CISA — ICS Advisories ICSA-26-134-01 through ICSA-26-134-16

cisa.gov/news-events/ics-advisories

Published 14 May 2026. Basis for energy and healthcare OT attack surface assessment.

GRID / REGULATORY

ERCOT — April 2026 Long-Term Load Forecast (PUCT Filing)

[Data Center Knowledge coverage, 14 May 2026 \(ERCOT/PUCT primary filing\)](#)

Basis for ERCOT demand concentration and grid vulnerability assessment.

LEGAL / GOVERNANCE

Crowell & Moring — CI Fortify Client Alert

crowell.com/en/insights/client-alerts/cisas-ci-fortify-initiative-signals-new-expectations

14 May 2026. Cited for legal and governance framing of post-incident liability only.

INDUSTRY / SURVEY

Healthcare IT Today — Healthcare Execs Under Siege Due to Ransomware Attacks

healthcareittoday.com/2026/05/15/healthcare-execs-under-siege-due-to-ransomware-attacks/

15 May 2026. Survey data from Censuswide 2025. Cited for ransomware prevalence data only.

TORCH FUSION CYCLE

WHAT: The week of 10–16 May 2026 was defined by convergence, not a single incident: CISA published sixteen ICS advisories on 14 May; ERCOT/PUCT reporting reinforced that conservative summer-demand estimates already exceed the historical peak; healthcare ransomware reporting on 15 May reinforced continuity pressure; and current-week legal analysis treated CI Fortify as a new governance expectation even though the initiative launched before this collection window. **WHO:** CISA, ERCOT/PUCT, and healthcare-sector reporting defined the current-week evidence base. PRC Volt Typhoon and Salt Typhoon clusters remain the strategic pre-positioning reference threat. Iranian IRGC-affiliated OT actors remain the disruption reference threat. DPRK IT-worker activity remains a carried-forward supply-chain governance risk from ATB-2026-9. **WHY:** PRC pre-positioning supports future crisis leverage; Iranian OT activity supports retaliatory disruption options; DPRK remote-work infiltration supports sanctions evasion and weapons-program revenue; ransomware actors exploit healthcare downtime pressure. Texas matters because grid, telecom, cloud, finance, healthcare, DIB, and AI/data-center dependencies are tightly coupled. **WHAT NEXT:** Leadership should expect CI Fortify concepts to shape sector-specific expectations, CIRCIA readiness, insurance questions, and board oversight discussions. The immediate task is not to buy another tool. It is to know which dependency breaks first, who owns the decision, and what record shows leadership acted before the event. *Warnings that arrive too late are not warnings. They are after-action reports.*

For tailored executive briefings or advisory retainer inquiries: intel@libertycti.com · libertycti.com

© 2026 Liberty CTI LLC. All rights reserved. The Alamo Threat Brief and its original analysis may not be reproduced or redistributed without permission.

Liberty CTI assessments reflect analytical judgments based on information available at the time of publication. Forecasts and warning judgments involve uncertainty and may change as new information becomes available. The Alamo Threat Brief provides intelligence decision support and does not constitute legal, financial, investment, or technical cybersecurity advice. See [Terms of Use](#).

Third-party reporting cited in this brief remains the property of its respective owners; citation does not constitute endorsement. Liberty CTI's original analytical judgments remain Liberty CTI intellectual property.

Test what this means for your organization.

EXECUTIVE INTELLIGENCE BASELINE + EXECUTIVE DECISION EXERCISE →

© 2026 Liberty CTI LLC. All rights reserved. The Alamo Threat Brief and its original analysis may not be reproduced or redistributed without permission. Alamo Threat Brief™ is a trademark of Liberty CTI LLC. This document is an archival companion to the published web issue and preserves the assessment as originally issued.